

No respite in Hormuz

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【要点】

- ・ホルムズ海峡と紅海周辺の海上セキュリティ危機が緩和する兆しを見せておらず、8月初旬の2週間で英国海事当局が12件の攻撃・事件警告を発令し、ドローン攻撃を受けたタンカーも報告されている。
- ・ホルムズ海峡と紅海における船舶への攻撃が相次いでおり、ミサイル被弾、タンカー近辺の爆発、軍勢との衝突などの事件が発生している。
- ・イラン支援下のフーシ派は「海上封鎖に対する海上封鎖」政策を継続する方針を示す一方で、特定対象外の船舶に対しては無料の「安全通航サービス」を提供している。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By TOMMASO LECCA with JORDYN DAHL and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — The maritime s

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

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SNEAK PEEK

— The maritime security crisis around the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea shows little sign of easing.

— Air traffic controllers summer performance is reigniting a debate over how the EU should regulate and finance air traffic management after 2030.

— Chinese electric vehicle sales are soaring across Europe with some financial help from national subsidy programs.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

G'day, from Canberra: POLITICO Australia is officially here, and the first-ever edition of Canberra Playbook is out now , bringing our signature mix of scoops, sharp analysis and insider intelligence to the people and power shaping politics Down Under. Australia may not be the 28th EU member state, but it's getting closer — part of the bloc's conversations about China, critical minerals, energy security, climate policy, trade and democratic resilience. Led by the original author of Brussels Playbook, Ryan Heath, the Canberra Playbook team takes you inside the political decisions shaping Australia.

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DRIVING THE DAY

NO REST FOR WICKED WATERS: The maritime security crisis around the Strait of Hormuz and Red Sea shows little sign of easing, with the U.K.'s maritime security authority issuing 12 attack and incident warnings in the first two weeks of August — including two tankers struck by drones in Hormuz on Friday.

A steady drumbeat: Of the 12 U.K. Maritime Trade Operations notices since Aug. 1, nine concerned Hormuz or the Gulf of Oman. Incidents have included vessels struck by projectiles, explosions near tankers and a container ship involved in an incident with military forces.

Red Sea too: Three of the UKMTO notices concerned waters off Yemen. A cargo vessel was hit by an unidentified projectile off Al Mokha on Aug. 11, with casualties reported, while another vessel attacked by an uncrewed surface vessel near the same port earlier in the month caught fire and sank after its crew was rescued.

Houthis hold the line: The leader of the Iran-backed Houthis, Mahdi al-Mashat, said the group's "blockade for blockade" policy against Saudi Arabia would continue until its objectives are achieved. However, the Houthis also said vessels outside the scope of their declared ban can transit Bab el-Mandeb, the Red Sea, Gulf of Aden and Arabian Sea freely. They offer companies a voluntary and free "Safe Transit Service" to seek assurances before sailing.

Shadow fleet warning: Against this volatile backdrop, an environmental disaster off Oman is highlighting another risk in the same waters: Russia's opaque shadow fleet. The EU- and U.K.-sanctioned tanker Caroline Bezengi, carrying around 1 million barrels of oil, is breaking up after grounding inside an Omani marine reserve following an unexplained explosion off Yemen.

A nightmare scenario: Maritime analyst Michelle Wiese Bockmann said the incident could be the shadow-fleet accident insurers have long warned about. Satellite analysis cited by Bockmann shows the oil slick expanding, while Oman's Environment Authority has reported contamination across roughly 400 square kilometers.

Who's responsible? The tanker was expelled from Cameroon's registry in June and is now effectively stateless, according to Bockmann, raising questions over who will ultimately pay for the clean-up and whether valid insurance is available to cover the costs. The accident exposes one of the biggest concerns surrounding Russia's shadow fleet: sanctioned tankers carrying large quantities of oil with opaque ownership, uncertain insurance and questionable flag arrangements can leave coastal states facing the environmental and financial consequences when something goes wrong.

AVIATION

SUMMER DELAY REDUCTION REIGNITES DEBATE OVER EU ATC TARGETS: This summer shows a drop in delays linked to air traffic control, but airlines remain unimpressed after years of poor performance. The disagreement is now feeding into a broader debate over how the EU should regulate and finance air traffic management after 2030. Watch your inboxes later today for Tommaso's story.

Targeting the targets: Airlines want air navigation service providers to comply with the EU's performance targets for en-route delays, which fall from 0.9 minutes of delay per flight in 2025 to 0.7 minutes in 2026, before tightening further to 0.5 minutes by 2028. They remain out of reach, with capacity and staffing constraints generating around 1.4 minutes of delay per flight. ANSPs and air traffic controller unions, however, argue that the targets themselves — together with the rules governing

ANSP charging schemes — need to be reconsidered.

The debate comes as the Commission prepares the next set of performance targets for the so-called Reference Period 5 between 2030 and 2034. Canso Europe, which represents ANSPs, sees the review as an opportunity to reverse the cost-cutting approach that followed the pandemic and allow greater investment in staffing and capacity. “ANSPs are not funded by their governments but rather through the services they provide to airlines: in 2020/2021, this income fell drastically and therefore they had to cut costs,” said Enrico Parini, Canso Europe’s director of European affairs.

Worrying situation: “From an air traffic management point of view, we have concerns about restrictions on what ANSPs can invest,” he added, noting that it takes two to three years to recruit and train a new air traffic controller. “The introduction of new technologies and systems can take even longer,” Parini told Tommaso.

Fewer cuts, more investment: He argued that current EU performance rules prioritize cost efficiency over long-term investment. That’s why Canso wants “the new iteration of the EU regulatory scheme, beginning in 2030, to support ANSP investment in future airspace capacity above cost efficiency savings.”

Unions agree: The European Transport Workers’ Federation has repeatedly argued that prioritizing cost efficiency and traffic growth “risks weakening the very system it seeks to optimise.”

Carriers have demands too: Airlines also want the system to change — but with the aim of reducing delays and costs for carriers and passengers rather than easing investment rules for ANSPs. “Air traffic flow management delays increased by 114 percent between 2015 and 2024,” said Neva Sadikoglu Novaky, head of the EU office of airline lobby IATA. “European citizens are still waiting for the benefits of an airspace system that includes binding performance targets on costs, effective and independent economic regulation, and a strong Network Manager,” she added, referring to Eurocontrol’s current role.

CARS

FUNDING THE COMPETITION: German luxury automaker Porsche filed paperwork earlier this month with the European Commission revealing it is joining the emissions pool of Chinese EV manufacturer XPeng. That means the Volkswagen subsidiary will pay the Chinese automaker for its emissions credits as Porsche reverses its electrification strategy in favor of combustion engine cars.

An explanation: Automakers across the EU have to hit emission reduction targets or face fines. But one way around the fine is to pool with other brands. So if a company like XPeng overshoots the target, it can sell the excess emission credits to lagging automakers.

Why it matters: Porsche and its parent company VW are shedding tens of thousands of jobs and shuttering factories across Germany. The sector is in crisis just as the sales of Chinese electric vehicles surge across the continent.

Not an isolated case: Taxpayer money in the form of government subsidies is also going into the coffers of Chinese EV manufacturers, particularly in Germany where both domestic and Chinese brands can qualify. Lawmakers are calling on the government of Chancellor Friedrich Merz to reform the program to block Chinese automakers.

Watch for Jordyn’s story later today.

PRESSURE FOR A GERMAN SUBSIDY REVAMP: Bavarian Premier Markus Söder wants the electric vehicle subsidy to be revised this fall so that it benefits domestic manufacturers more. Alexander Hoffmann, leader of the Christian Social Union parliamentary group, told our Berlin colleague Thorsten Mumme that could be “specifically linked to criteria such as local battery production, material usage, or short transport routes.”

SPD AGREES: “The electric vehicle subsidy is the most obvious application for local content criteria,” said Sebastian Roloff, spokesperson for the Social Democratic Party’s economic policy group. “Therefore, we should enshrine local content wherever public funds are involved.”

Kumbaya moment: “On this basis, I believe a unified German position is quite achievable,” said Roloff. “In Brussels, we can only be convincing with a united voice anyway.”

Limiting luxury cars: Automotive expert Ferdinand Dudenhöffer suggested that the subsidy have upper limits based on the vehicle price.

CHINA FUNDING THE GLOBAL SHIFT TO A GREEN ECONOMY: China’s push into clean technologies like batteries, electric vehicles and solar panels is helping to lower costs worldwide but is growing geopolitical and economic tensions, according to a new study from the University of Manchester that will be published later today and was seen ahead of time by POLITICO.

Tricky choice: “China’s dominance of green technology presents a fundamental dilemma for governments,” James Jackson, the report’s lead author, said in a statement. “The world needs these technologies to decarbonize, but efforts to compete with China risk making the transition more expensive and more difficult.”

PIT STOPS

From us : New U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham’s government has brought forward a review of mandated electric vehicle sales targets for automakers.

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